

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ
بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 20 and 21

Murakkabat Naqisah · the Murakkab Tawsifi

1. Mufrad and Murakkab

Any word — whether an *Ism*, a *Fi'l* or a *Harf* — when used alone, apart from a sentence, is called a *Mufrad* in the terminology of Arabic grammar. And when a *mufrad* joins another *mufrad*, a *Murakkab* is formed.

Kind	Definition	Examples
Murakkab Tamm	A Murakkab from which the sense is fully understood. The Jumla Ismiyyah is a major example of it, whose basic condition is that the first noun be Ma'rifah and the second Nakirah, and that both be Marfoo'.	رَبِّدٌ صَالِحٌ
Murakkab Naqis	A combination of two or more words from which the sense is not completed.	a good boy , the boy's book , this book , in the book

2. The Murakkab Tawsifi

Definition: A *Murakkab Tawsifi* is that *Murakkab Naqis* in which the second noun states some merit, fault or quality of the first noun.

It has two elements:

- *Sifah* — by which is meant a merit or a fault.
- *Mawsuf* — the noun whose quality is being stated is called the *Mawsuf*.

The rule of order: In forming a *Murakkab Tawsifi* in Arabic, the *Mawsuf* is written first and the *Sifah* after it.

As in الصِّرَاطُ الْمُسْتَقِيمُ and شَيْءٌ قَلِيلٌ، النَّفْسُ الْمُطْمَئِنَّةُ.

3. The four aspects of agreement

The governing principle: In a *Murakkab Tawsifi* agreement between the *Mawsuf* and the *Sifah* is required in **all four aspects** of the noun. That is, in *jins*, *'adad*, *wus'at* and *l'raab* the *Sifah* follows the *Mawsuf*.

In a *Murakkab Tawsifi* the first noun is the *Mawsuf* and the second is its *Sifah*. One *Mawsuf* may take a single *Sifah* and may also take more than one, and all the qualities follow the *Mawsuf* in all four respects.

Recognising the l'raab: The *l'raab* of a *Murakkab Tawsifi* is always recognised by the *Mawsuf*, because the real standing belongs to the *Mawsuf* and the *Sifah* follows it in every respect.

3.1 In respect of Jins

If the *Mawsuf* is masculine the *Sifah* will be masculine too, and if the *Mawsuf* is feminine the *Sifah* will be feminine.

Mudhakkar	Mu'annath
مُعَلِّمٌ قَائِمٌ	بِنْتُ صَادِقَةٍ
مُعَلِّمَانِ قَائِمَانِ	بَنَتَانِ صَادِقَتَانِ
مُعَلِّمُونَ قَائِمُونَ	بَنَاتٌ صَادِقَاتٌ

3.2 In respect of Wus'at

If the *Mawsuf* is *Ma'rifah* the *Sifah* is *Ma'rifah* too, and if the *Mawsuf* is *Nakirah* the *Sifah* is *Nakirah*. In a *Murakkab Tawsifi* the *Mawsuf* may be either.

Ma'rifah	Nakirah
النَّفْسُ الْمُطْمَئِنَّةُ	أَجْرٌ عَظِيمٌ
الصِّرَاطُ الْمُسْتَقِيمُ	شَيْءٌ قَلِيلٌ

3.3 In respect of 'Adad

If the *Mawsuf* is *Wahid*, *Tathniyah* or *Jam'*, the *Sifah* will be so as well.

- الْوَلَدُ الصَّالِحُ
- الْوَلَدَانِ الصَّالِحَانِ
- الْأَوْلَادُ الصَّالِحُونَ

An important allowance: If the *Mawsuf* is a *Jam' Mukassar* and the *Sifah* a *Jam' Salim*, the *Murakkab Tawsifi* is still sound. The only condition is that the *Sifah* match the *Mawsuf* in number.

3.4 In respect of I'raab

Whatever state of *I'raab* the *Mawsuf* is in, the *Sifah* will be in that same state.

الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ ، كِتَابٌ مُبِينٌ ، أَجْرٌ عَظِيمٌ ، الصِّرَاطُ الْمُسْتَقِيمُ
مَتَاعٌ قَلِيلٌ ، صَبْرٌ جَمِيلٌ ، عَرْشٌ عَظِيمٌ ، كَلِمَتَانِ حَبِيبَتَانِ

4. Complete tables of Mawsuf and Sifah

Nakirah Mudhakkar

State	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
Marfoo'	رَجُلٌ صَالِحٌ	رَجُلَانِ صَالِحَيْنِ	رِجَالٌ صَالِحُونَ
Mansoob	رَجُلًا صَالِحًا	رَجُلَيْنِ صَالِحَيْنِ	رِجَالًا صَالِحِينَ
Majroor	رَجُلٍ صَالِحٍ	رَجُلَيْنِ صَالِحَيْنِ	رِجَالٍ صَالِحِينَ

(a righteous man · two righteous men · righteous men)

Nakirah Mu'annath

State	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
Marfoo'	إِمْرَأَةٌ صَالِحَةٌ	إِمْرَأَتَانِ صَالِحَتَانِ	نِسَاءٌ صَالِحَاتٌ
Mansoob	إِمْرَأَةً صَالِحَةً	إِمْرَأَتَيْنِ صَالِحَتَيْنِ	نِسَاءً صَالِحَاتٍ
Majroor	إِمْرَأَةٍ صَالِحَةٍ	إِمْرَأَتَيْنِ صَالِحَتَيْنِ	نِسَاءٍ صَالِحَاتٍ

(a righteous woman · two righteous women · righteous women)

Ma'rifah Mudhakkar

State	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
Marfoo'	الرَّجُلُ الصَّالِحُ	الرَّجُلَانِ الصَّالِحَانِ	الرِّجَالُ الصَّالِحُونَ
Mansoob	الرَّجُلَ الصَّالِحَ	الرَّجُلَيْنِ الصَّالِحَيْنِ	الرِّجَالَ الصَّالِحِينَ
Majroor	الرَّجُلِ الصَّالِحِ	الرَّجُلَيْنِ الصَّالِحَيْنِ	الرِّجَالِ الصَّالِحِينَ

(the righteous man · the two righteous men · the righteous men)

Ma'rifah Mu'annath

State	Wahid	Tathniyah	Jam'
Marfoo'	الْمَرْأَةُ الصَّالِحَةُ	الْمَرْأَتَانِ الصَّالِحَتَانِ	النِّسَاءُ الصَّالِحَاتُ
Mansoob	الْمَرْأَةُ الصَّالِحَةُ	الْمَرْأَتَيْنِ الصَّالِحَتَيْنِ	النِّسَاءُ الصَّالِحَاتِ
Majroor	الْمَرْأَةُ الصَّالِحَةُ	الْمَرْأَتَيْنِ الصَّالِحَتَيْنِ	النِّسَاءِ الصَّالِحَاتِ

(the righteous woman · the two righteous women · the righteous women)

5. The du'a after the Fajr prayer

The Prophet, peace be upon him, used to say this du'a after the Fajr prayer:

اَللّٰهُمَّ اِنِّیْ اَسْأَلُكَ عِلْمًا نَافِعًا، وَعَمَلًا مُتَقَبَّلًا، وَرِزْقًا طَيِّبًا

Translation: O Allah, I ask You for beneficial knowledge, for accepted deeds, and for wholesome provision.

Three *Murakkabat Naqisah* are used in this du'a, and all three are *Murakkab Tawsifi*: عَمَلًا, عِلْمًا نَافِعًا, رِزْقًا طَيِّبًا and مُتَقَبَّلًا.

Murakkab	Mawsuf	Sifah	Translation
عِلْمًا نَافِعًا	عِلْمًا	نَافِعًا	beneficial knowledge
عَمَلًا مُتَقَبَّلًا	عَمَلًا	مُتَقَبَّلًا	an accepted deed
رِزْقًا طَيِّبًا	رِزْقًا	طَيِّبًا	wholesome provision

In all three, the *Mawsuf* and the *Sifah* are equal in all four respects: both *Nakirah*, both singular, both masculine and both *Mansoob*. They are therefore three *Mansoob Murakkab Tawsifi*.

6. Translating a Murakkab Tawsifi

In English, as in Urdu, it is generally more natural to render the *Sifah* first and the *Mawsuf* after it — "beneficial knowledge", "an accepted deed", "wholesome provision".

It is equally correct, however, to render the *Mawsuf* first: "knowledge that benefits", "a deed that is accepted", "provision that is wholesome".

The rule for translating a Nakirah

Rule: When a *Nakirah* noun comes in Arabic, it is rendered with "a", "some" or "a certain", as in إِمَامٌ عَادِلٌ — "a just ruler".

But not here: In the du'a above, عَلِمًا نَافِعًا cannot be rendered "some knowledge" or "a certain knowledge", because the context is one of supplication. Here the rendering is "knowledge that benefits". Likewise رِزْقًا طَيِّبًا is "provision that is wholesome" and عَمَلًا مُتَقَبَّلًا is "a deed that is accepted".

And if the *Mawsuf* is *Ma'rifah*, the sense of "the" or "that" enters the translation, not "a".

7. Examples from Surah al-Ghashiyah

هَلْ أَتَاكَ حَدِيثُ الْعَاشِيَةِ * وَجُوهٌ يَوْمَئِذٍ خَاشِعَةٌ * عَامِلَةٌ نَّاصِبَةٌ * تَصْلَى نَارًا حَامِيَةً * تُسْقَى مِنْ عَيْنٍ آنِيَةٍ *
 وَجُوهٌ يَوْمَئِذٍ نَّاعِمَةٌ * لَسَعِيهَا رَاضِيَةٌ * فِي جَنَّةٍ عَالِيَةٍ * فِيهَا عَيْنٌ جَارِيَةٌ * فِيهَا سُرُرٌ مَرْفُوعَةٌ * وَأَكْوَابٌ
 مَوْضُوعَةٌ * وَنَمَارِقُ مَصْفُوفَةٌ * وَزَرَّابِيُّ مَبْثُوثَةٌ *

(Surah al-Ghashiyah: 1 to 16)

7.1 'Amilatun Nasibah — an exception

Element	Details
عَامِلَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: labouring
نَّاصِبَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: weary, bearing hardship
The principle	A Sifah does not take a Sifah of its own; a Sifah belongs to a Mawsuf. Here the first word, عَامِلَةٌ, is itself a Sifah.

Conclusion: This is not a Murakkab Tawsifi. Both words are qualities of وَجُوهٌ in verse 2 — one Mawsuf with two Sifahs.

7.2 Naran Hamiyah

Element	Details
نَارًا	an Ism Dhat, meaning: fire
حَامِيَةً	a Sifah, meaning: intensely hot
Agreement	both Nakirah, both singular, both feminine, both Mansoob

Conclusion: نَارًا حَامِيَةً is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: a blazing fire, or a fire that is intensely hot.

7.3 'Aynin Aniyah

Element	Details
عَيْن	an Ism Dhat, meaning: a spring
أَنِية	a Sifah, meaning: boiling
Agreement	both Nakirah, both singular, both feminine, both Majroor

Conclusion: عَيْنُ أَنِية is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: a boiling spring, or a spring that is boiling.

7.4 Jannatin 'Aliyah

Element	Details
جَنَّة	an Ism Dhat, meaning: a garden
عَالِيَة	a Sifah, meaning: elevated
Agreement	both Nakirah, both singular, both feminine, both Majroor

Conclusion: جَنَّةٌ عَالِيَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: an elevated garden, or a garden that is elevated.

7.5 'Aynun Jariyah

Element	Details
عَيْن	an Ism Dhat, meaning: a spring
جَارِيَة	a Sifah, meaning: flowing
Agreement	both Nakirah, both singular, both feminine, both Marfoo'

Conclusion: عَيْنٌ جَارِيَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: a flowing spring, or a spring that flows.

7.6 Sururun Marfoo'ah

Element	Details
سُرُرٌ	an Ism Dhat, meaning: couches or thrones; the plural of سَرِيرٌ
مَرْفُوعَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: raised up
An important rule	سُرُرٌ is a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil. The Sifah of a Ghayr 'Aqil plural may come as singular feminine and may also come as a feminine plural. Here it has come as singular feminine.

Conclusion: سُرُرٌ مَرْفُوعَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: raised couches.

7.7 Akwabun Mawdoo'ah

Element	Details
أَكْوَابٌ	an Ism Dhat, meaning: cups; the plural of كُؤْبٌ
مَوْضُوعَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: set in place
The rule	أَكْوَابٌ is a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil, which is why the Sifah has come as singular feminine

Conclusion: أَكْوَابٌ مَوْضُوعَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: cups set in place.

7.8 Namariqu Masfoofah

Element	Details
نَمَارِقُ	an Ism Dhat, the plural of نَمْرَقَةٌ, meaning: small cushions or bolsters
Its I'raab	نَمَارِقُ is a Jam' Mukassar and Ghayr Munsarif, belonging to the class of Ghayr Munsarif nouns on the pattern مَفَاعِلُ
مَصْفُوفَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: ranged in rows, set in order
The rule	نَمَارِقُ is a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil, which is why its Sifah has come as singular feminine

Conclusion: نَمَارِقُ مَصْفُوفَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: cushions ranged in rows.

7.9 Zarabiyyu Mabthoothah

Element	Details
زَرَابِيُّ	an Ism Dhat, the plural of زَرِيَّةٌ, meaning: fine carpets, rich rugs
Its I'raab	زَرَابِيُّ is likewise a Jam' Mukassar and Ghayr Munsarif, belonging to the class on the pattern مَفَاعِيلُ
مَبْثُوثَةٌ	a Sifah, meaning: spread out, laid down
The rule	زَرَابِيُّ is a plural of the Ghayr 'Aqil, which is why its Sifah has come as singular feminine

Conclusion: زَرَابِيُّ مَبْثُوثَةٌ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: carpets spread out, or rich rugs laid down.

8. Examples from other Surahs

8.1 As-Sirat al-Mustaqeem — Surah al-Fatihah: 6

Element	Details
الصِّرَاطِ	an Ism Dhat, meaning: a path
الْمُسْتَقِيمِ	a Sifah, meaning: straight
Agreement	both Ma'rifah, both singular, both masculine, both Mansoob

Conclusion: الصِّرَاطِ الْمُسْتَقِيمِ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: the straight path, or the path that is straight.

A point on translation: If the *Mawsuf* is *Ma'rifah*, the sense of "the" enters the translation, not "a".

8.2 Al-Qur'an al-Hakeem — Surah Ya-Sin: 2

Element	Details
الْقُرْآنِ	an Ism Dhat
الْحَكِيمِ	a Sifah, meaning: full of wisdom

Element	Details
Agreement	both Ma'rifah, both singular, both masculine, both Majroor

Conclusion: الْقُرْآنُ الْحَكِيمُ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: the wise Qur'an, or the Qur'an that is full of wisdom.

8.3 Al-Ard al-Muqaddasah

Element	Details
الْأَرْضُ	an Ism Dhat, meaning: the land
الْمُقَدَّسَةُ	a Sifah, meaning: holy
Agreement	both Ma'rifah, both singular, both feminine, both Marfoo'

Conclusion: الْأَرْضُ الْمُقَدَّسَةُ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: the holy land, or the land that is holy.

8.4 An-Nafs al-Mutma'innah — Surah al-Fajr: 27

Element	Details
النَّفْسُ	an Ism Dhat, meaning: the soul
الْمُطْمَئِنَّةُ	a Sifah, meaning: at peace, tranquil
Agreement	both Ma'rifah, both singular, both feminine, both Marfoo'

Conclusion: النَّفْسُ الْمُطْمَئِنَّةُ is a Murakkab Tawsifi.

Translation: O soul at peace.

9. The three forms of the Sifah for a Ghayr 'Aqil plural

Rule: The *Sifah* of a *Ghayr 'Aqil* plural may come in three forms: **singular feminine** (which is the most common), a **feminine plural**, and a **Jam' Mukassar**.

Form	Example	Meaning
singular feminine	صُحُفٌ مُّطَهَّرَةٌ	purified scriptures
singular feminine	أَيَّامًا مَّعْدُودَةً	a few numbered days
feminine plural	أَيَّامٍ مَّعْدُودَاتٍ	numbered days
feminine plural	أَشْهُرٌ مَّعْلُومَاتٌ	well-known months
Jam' Mukassar	بَقَرَاتٍ سِمَانٍ	fat cows

10. Building a Murakkab Tawsifi from English into Arabic

Aspect	Principle
Order	The Mawsuf comes first, then the Sifah
Agreement	The Sifah matches the Mawsuf in all four respects: being Ma'rifah or Nakirah, being Wahid or Tathniyah or Jam', being Mudhakkar or Mu'annath, and in I'raab
Nakirah	If the English has "a", "some" or "a certain", the Mawsuf will generally be Nakirah
Ma'rifah	If some particular thing is meant, both the Mawsuf and the Sifah will be Ma'rifah

Summary

1. Any word used alone, apart from a sentence, is called Mufrad, and when a mufrad joins another mufrad a Murakkab is formed.
2. The Murakkab is of two kinds: the Murakkab Tamm, from which the sense is complete, and the Murakkab Naqis, from which it is not.
3. A Murakkab Tawsifi is that Murakkab Naqis in which the second noun states some merit, fault or quality of the first.
4. It has two elements: the Sifah and the Mawsuf. In Arabic the Mawsuf comes first and the Sifah after it.
5. Agreement between the Mawsuf and the Sifah is required in all four aspects: jins, 'adad, wus'at and l'raab.
6. One Mawsuf may take a single Sifah and may take more than one, and all of them follow the Mawsuf.
7. The l'raab of a Murakkab Tawsifi is always recognised by the Mawsuf, since the real standing belongs to it.
8. If the Mawsuf is a Jam' Mukassar and the Sifah a Jam' Salim the construction is still sound; the only condition is agreement in number.
9. The du'a after Fajr contains three Mansoob Murakkab Tawsifi: رَزَقًا طَيِّبًا and عَلِمًا نَافِعًا, عَمَلًا مُتَّقِبًا.
10. In translating, rendering the Sifah first is more natural, though rendering the Mawsuf first is also correct.
11. A Nakirah noun is generally rendered with "a" or "some", but in the context of supplication it is rendered as "such ... as".
12. If the Mawsuf is Ma'rifah, the sense of "the" enters the translation, not "a".
13. وَجُودُهُ غَامِلَةٌ نَاصِبَةٌ is not a Murakkab Tawsifi, since a Sifah takes no Sifah of its own; both are qualities of وَجُودُهُ.
14. In Surah al-Ghashiyah, عَيْنٌ جَارِيَةٌ and نَارًا حَامِيَةً, عَيْنٌ أَيْنِيَّةٌ, جَنَّةٌ عَالِيَةٌ are all Murakkab Tawsifi.
15. In رَزَائِي مَبْنُوتَةٌ and سُرُرٌ مَرْفُوعَةٌ, أَكْوَابٌ مَوْضُوعَةٌ, نَمَارِقُ مَصْفُوفَةٌ the Mawsuf is a Ghayr 'Aqil plural, which is why the Sifah is singular feminine.
16. رَزَائِي and نَمَارِقُ are both Jam' Mukassar and Ghayr Munsarif, standing on the patterns of Muntaha al-Jumoo'.
17. النَّفْسُ الْمُطْمَئِنَّةُ and الصِّرَاطُ الْمُسْتَقِيمُ, الْقُرْآنُ الْحَكِيمُ, الْأَرْضُ الْمُقَدَّسَةُ are examples of a Ma'rifah Murakkab Tawsifi.
18. The Sifah of a Ghayr 'Aqil plural may come in three forms: singular feminine, feminine plural, and Jam' Mukassar.
19. When building the construction, place the Mawsuf first and then make the Sifah match it in all four respects.

Exercise

1. Define Mufrad and Murakkab, and explain both kinds of Murakkab with examples.

2. Define the Murakkab Tawsifi and name both of its elements.
3. What is the order of the Mawsuf and the Sifah in Arabic?
4. Write all four aspects of agreement and give two examples of each.
5. By which of the two is the I'raab of a Murakkab Tawsifi recognised, and why?
6. Write the complete tables for the Nakirah Mudhakkar and the Ma'rifah Mu'annath in all three states.
7. Write the du'a said after Fajr, separate its three Murakkab Tawsifi and analyse each.
8. Explain both ways of translating a Murakkab Tawsifi with examples.
9. What is the rule for translating a Nakirah noun, and why does it change in the context of supplication?
10. Why is غَامِلَةٌ نَّاصِبَةٌ not a Murakkab Tawsifi?
11. Take four Murakkab Tawsifi from Surah al-Ghashiyah and write all four aspects of each.
12. Why has the Sifah come as singular feminine in سُرُرٌ مَرْفُوعَةٌ?
13. State the reason why نَمَارِقُ and زَرَائِفُ are Ghayr Munsarif.
14. Give a full analysis of النَّفْسُ الْمُظْمِئَةُ and الصِّرَاطُ الْمُسْتَقِيمُ.
15. Write the three forms of the Sifah for a Ghayr 'Aqil plural, with examples.
16. Build the Arabic Murakkab Tawsifi for: a righteous boy, the straight path, two pure women.

سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ